

PSYCHOLOGY OF OBESITY IN WOMEN

Not just lifestyle excesses...

- 1 The bias that fat people are lazy, eat all the time, lack self-discipline creates low self-esteem, depression and difficulty in losing weight.
- 2 Food is used in response to negative emotions: boredom, sadness, anger, feelings of emptiness, work and family pressures.
- 3 It takes a modest weight for a woman to experience weight discrimination, but men can gain far more weight without facing bias.
- 4 Changing vision of Indian feminine ideal—from more buxom to westernised, skinny prototypes—creates more pressure on women.
- 5 Juggling work and home, women often end up as workhorses, saddled with more responsibility than they can handle.
- 6 Stress ups obesity, unlocks body's fat cells and causes them to grow in both size and number. Stress also changes hormonal balance.
- 7 Pregnancies, lactation, change in body shape, lack of sexual drive in career-driven partners, feeling unwanted and losing interest in oneself.
- 8 Depression changes eating patterns, makes it difficult to motivate oneself to eat properly or keep weight under control.



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One of the reasons for obesity among **35+** women is the lack of sexual drive among husbands, says an AIIMS study

and diet counsellor in Bangalore—a consultant to corporates and also the National Cricket Academy. “I bloated up so much that by age nine, other girls started laughing at me.” For the next 25 years, there wasn’t a single day when she didn’t work at losing weight—experimenting with every conceivable diet, losing and gaining repeatedly. “Men can drown themselves in work, hang out with friends, bond over a smoke or a drink. But women can’t shut out responsibilities and end up internalising their stress. Food then becomes their biggest helpline.” Every pregnancy, every phase of lactation, make women more dependent on food, add to waistlines and lower self-image. John, however, decided to take things in hand when she reached 82 kg after her third pregnancy, cut out calorie-heavy food and arrived at her own formula, shedding 25 kg in a year.

But obese women are more than twice as likely to be depressed, exercise the least, have the poorest body image, and consume 20 per cent more calories, reports WHO. Dr Varsha Vaidya in her 2007 study on weight-loss failure and personality traits in the *VO* found an increased prevalence (40-60 per cent) of depression in obesity

patients. In India, where there are five women for one man suffering from depression, doctors admit that many women obesity patients report mental health issues—“social anxiety”, loss of self-esteem, isolation and vulnerability in social and private lives. “It’s difficult to separate the effects of depression on obesity,” says Trehan. “The neuroendocrine changes associated with depression may cause metabolic changes that predispose and perpetuate obesity.”

It’s nearly 60 years since Simone de Beauvoir famously wrote, one is not born a woman but becomes one. In the meantime, women have made it big in every sphere of our traditional society. Yet, many of their lives are still bedevilled by the three-letter word, fat. Perhaps they need to be told that being a bit overweight is probably not that harmful; that obesity is harmful, but so are lots of other things we do to ourselves; that obese people harm themselves but not others; that they don’t deserve the deadly prejudice that comes their way; that thinness and happiness are not synonymous. If feeling fat is an attitude of the mind, saying goodbye to it needs to start there too.

with Swati Mathur and Elora Sen